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Korean Food Guide

From sizzling BBQ to comforting soups, spicy stews to sweet street snacks — your complete guide to eating in Korea.



Must-Try Korean Dishes

These are the dishes every visitor to Korea should try at least once.



Samgyeopsal 삼겹살

Grilled pork belly cooked at your table on a charcoal or gas grill. Wrap in lettuce with garlic, green onion and ssamjang paste.

● Not spicy



Bibimbap 비빔밥

Rice topped with assorted vegetables, a fried egg, and gochujang (red chili paste). Mix everything together before eating.

● Mildly spicy (adjustable)



Kimchi Jjigae 김치찌개

Fermented kimchi simmered into a rich, deeply flavored stew with pork or tofu. Korea's ultimate comfort food.

● Spicy



Ramyeon 라면

Korean instant noodles — miles beyond the global version. Best eaten at a pojangmacha (street tent) at 2am.

● Mildly spicy



Nakji Bokkeum 낙지볶음



Japchae 잡채

Stir-fried spicy octopus — a dish that will clear your sinuses and delight your palate at the same time.

● Very spicy 🔥

Glass noodles stir-fried with vegetables, beef and sesame oil. A festive dish that's popular at celebrations.

● Not spicy



Chimaek

치맥

Korean fried chicken + beer (maekju) — a national institution. Crispy, saucy and made for sharing while watching sports.

● Not spicy (original) / spicy versions available



Sundubu Jjigae

순두부찌개

Soft silken tofu stew with egg, seafood or meat, served bubbling hot in a stone pot.

● Spicy



Dosirak

도시락

Korean lunch box — rice, protein and side dishes. Available at convenience stores for ₩3,000–5,000. A budget traveler's best friend.

● Varies



Korean BBQ Guide

Korean BBQ (고기구이, go-gi gu-i) is an experience, not just a meal. Here's how it works:

- 1 Sit down — banchan arrives automatically**
Small side dishes (반찬, ban-chan) are placed on the table for free — kimchi, pickled vegetables, bean sprouts, fish cake. Refills are always free, just ask.
- 2 Order your meat**
Popular choices: 삼겹살 (pork belly), 목살 (pork neck), 소갈비 (beef ribs), 불고기 (marinated beef). Most restaurants require a minimum of 2 servings per type.
- 3 The server grills (or you grill)**
At most mid-range restaurants, the server grills and cuts the meat for you. At cheaper spots, you're on your own — it's easy.
- 4 Make a ssam wrap**
Take a lettuce or perilla leaf, add rice, a piece of meat, garlic, sliced chili and a dab of ssamjang paste. Fold and eat in one bite.
- 5 End with naengmyeon or doenjang jjigae**

Koreans often finish BBQ with cold buckwheat noodles (냉면) or a soybean paste stew (된장찌개). Order separately.

💡 **BBQ Tips:** Your clothes will smell like smoke — that's normal and unavoidable. Many BBQ restaurants have coat hooks outside for that reason. Most have ventilation hoods above the grill but it still lingers. Plan accordingly.



Street Food



Tteokbokki (떡볶이)

Chewy rice cakes in sweet spicy red sauce. Korea's most beloved street food.



Hotteok (호떡)

Sweet pancake filled with brown sugar, cinnamon and nuts. Perfect winter food.



Odeng (어묵)

Fish cake skewers in hot broth — warming, savory and cheap (₩500 each).



Roasted Corn (구운 옥수수)

Charcoal-roasted corn with butter — common at beaches and market stalls.



Bingsu (빙수)

Shaved ice with sweetened red bean, condensed milk and toppings. Korea's iconic summer dessert.



Dakgangjeong (닭강정)

Sweet crispy fried chicken bites — addictively good, especially from Myeongdong vendors.



Vegetarian & Dietary Tips

EATING WITH DIETARY RESTRICTIONS

- **Vegetarian:** Traditional Korean Buddhist temple food (사찰음식) is fully vegan. Look for 사찰 식당 (temple food restaurants). Bibimbap and japchae can often be made without meat — ask.
- **Vegan:** Harder than vegetarian — many broths contain anchovy or beef stock. Say "고기 없이 해주세 요" (go-gi eop-si hae-ju-se-yo) — no meat please.
- **Gluten-free:** Rice is the staple so many dishes are naturally GF. Soy sauce (간장) contains gluten — ask for gluten-free soy (글루텐프리 간장).
- **Halal:** Growing availability in Itaewon (Seoul) and Dongdaemun. Search "Halal restaurant Korea" on Naver Maps.



Budget Guide — How Much Does Food Cost?

AVERAGE MEAL PRICES (2026)

- **Convenience store meal** (dosirak + drink): ₩4,000–6,000 (~\$3–4)
- **Street food snack** (tteokbokki, odeng): ₩2,000–4,000 (~\$1.50–3)
- **Local restaurant lunch set**: ₩8,000–12,000 (~\$6–9)
- **Korean BBQ per person**: ₩15,000–25,000 (~\$11–18)
- **Upscale restaurant**: ₩30,000–60,000+ per person
- **Chimaek (chicken + beer) for 2**: ₩30,000–40,000 (~\$22–30)



Food Korean — Order Like a Local

이거 주세요.	<i>i-geo ju-se-yo.</i>	I'll have this. (pointing)
맵지 않게 해주세요.	<i>maep-ji an-ke hae-ju-se-yo.</i>	Please make it not spicy.
반찬 더 주세요.	<i>ban-chan deo ju-se-yo.</i>	More side dishes, please.
맛있어요!	<i>ma-si-sseo-yo!</i>	It's delicious!
추천해 주세요.	<i>chu-cheon-hae ju-se-yo.</i>	Please recommend something.
고기 없이 해주세요.	<i>go-gi eop-si hae-ju-se-yo.</i>	No meat, please.
포장해 주세요.	<i>po-jang-hae ju-se-yo.</i>	To go, please.
계산해 주세요.	<i>gye-san-hae ju-se-yo.</i>	Check, please.

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